IELTS Reading Module Guide

Prepared by Mehak Hussain

Description

IELTS Reading is **60 minutes** for **3 passages** and **40 questions**. There is **no extra transfer time**: on the paper test, answers must be on the answer sheet within the 60 minutes (IDP IELTS). Each correct answer earns 1 mark, and the score out of 40 is converted to a band from 0 to 9 (IDP IELTS).

	Academic Reading	General Training Reading
Passages	3 long passages, each about 700–900 words	3 sections with shorter, practical texts
Sources	Books, journals, magazines and newspapers	Notices, adverts, timetables, workplace documents, magazine and book extracts
Difficulty	Increases from Passage 1 to Passage 3	Increases from Section 1 to Section 3
Questions	Usually 13–14 per passage, 40 in total	40 in total

The passages get harder as you go, and at least one Academic passage contains a detailed logical argument (Prep Education). Spelling and grammar in your answers count, so a misspelled answer is marked wrong.

On the computer-delivered test

- **There is no search function (Ctrl + F).** You can't search the passage for a word, so you still need to skim and scan with your eyes. Practise scanning on screen before test day.
- **There is a highlighter.** Select a word or phrase with the mouse and choose Highlight. Use it to mark key words in the questions and the matching words in the passage (IDP IELTS).
- The passage often doesn't fit on one screen, so you will need to scroll. The passage and questions sit side by side.

Types of questions

There are 11 official question types (IDP IELTS). Questions in the same group usually follow the order of the passage, **except** matching headings, matching information and matching features.

#	Question type	What you do	How to handle it	Gives a quick overview?
1	Multiple choice	Choose 1 answer from 4, or 2–3 answers from a longer list	Underline key words in the question, find the part of the text, then rule out wrong options	Sometimes (if it asks about the main idea or writer's purpose)
2	Identifying information (True / False / Not Given)	Decide if a statement agrees with the facts in the text	Find the exact sentence; judge only on what the text says	No – detail

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#	Question type	What you do	How to handle it	Gives a quick overview?
3	Identifying writer's views (Yes / No / Not Given)	Decide if a statement agrees with the writer's opinion	Look for opinion words (believes, argues, claims, should)	No – detail
4	Matching information	Find which paragraph contains a piece of information	Paragraphs can be used more than once; do these after you know the passage	Partly
5	Matching headings	Choose the best heading for each paragraph	Read the first 1–2 and last sentence of each paragraph; there are more headings than paragraphs	**Yes – best for a quick overview**
6	Matching features	Match statements to people, dates or theories	Scan for the names first, then read around each one	Partly
7	Matching sentence endings	Choose the correct ending for each sentence	Check grammar as well as meaning; there are extra endings	No – detail
8	Sentence completion	Fill a gap with words from the text	Obey the word limit and copy the spelling exactly	No – detail
9	Summary / note / table / flow-chart completion	Fill gaps in a summary of part of the text	Find which paragraph the summary covers; predict the word type (noun, verb, number)	Yes, if the summary covers the whole passage
10	Diagram label completion	Label parts of a diagram with words from the text	The text usually describes the diagram in one section; scan for it	No – detail
11	Short-answer questions	Answer questions in a few words from the text	Use the WH word to know what to look for; obey the word limit	No – detail

Attempting strategy

Attempt Passage 3 first. It is the hardest and takes the most time, so do it while your mind is fresh. Passages 1 and 2 are easier and faster, so they fit into the remaining time.

Don't read the whole passage. There isn't time to read about 2,500 words carefully and answer 40 questions. Skim the passage for the general idea, then go back only to the parts the questions point to.

In each passage, choose the question types that give a quick overview first. Matching headings, a summary that covers the whole passage, or a main-idea multiple-choice question show you what each paragraph is about. Once you know the layout of the passage, the detail questions (True / False / Not Given, sentence completion, short answers) become much faster.

Suggested timing

Order	Passage	Time	Why
1st	Passage 3	22 minutes	Hardest passage, done with a fresh mind

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Order	Passage	Time	Why
2nd	Passage 1	16 minutes	Easiest; build your score quickly
3rd	Passage 2	18 minutes	Medium difficulty
Last	Check and transfer	4 minutes	Fill any blanks and check spelling

Watch the clock: if Passage 3 reaches 22 minutes, move on and come back later. Running out of time on easy Passage 1 questions loses more marks than leaving one hard question.

Steps for each passage

1. **Skim (2–3 minutes):** read the title, any subheadings, and the first sentence of each paragraph to get the general idea.
2. **Overview questions first:** answer matching headings or whole-passage summary questions.
3. **Underline key words** in each detail question, especially names, numbers, dates and capitalised words, because they are easy to scan for.
4. **Scan** the text for those key words or their synonyms, then read only the sentences around them carefully.
5. **Write the answer straight onto the answer sheet** (paper test), because there is no extra transfer time.
6. **Never leave a blank.** There is no negative marking, so guess any answer you couldn't find.

Key skills

Skimming vs scanning

Skill	Purpose	How
Skimming	Get the general idea of a passage or paragraph	Read the title, first and last sentence of each paragraph; let your eyes move quickly over the rest
Scanning	Find one specific piece of information	Search for a key word, name, number or date without reading every word, then stop and read closely around it

Paraphrase: the questions don't use the text's words

The questions almost always say the same thing as the passage in different words. Train yourself to spot synonyms.

In the question	In the passage
expensive	cost a fortune, high-priced
decreased	fell, declined, dropped
researchers	scientists, academics, experts
old people	the elderly, senior citizens
caused	led to, resulted in, was responsible for
not widely accepted	controversial, disputed

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True / False / Not Given vs Yes / No / Not Given

True / False / Not Given asks about **facts**. Yes / No / Not Given asks about **the writer's opinions or claims**. The logic is the same:

Answer	Meaning
True / Yes	The text clearly says the same thing
False / No	The text clearly says the **opposite**
Not Given	The text says nothing about it, or not enough to decide

Example text: "The library opened in 1990 and now has over 50,000 books."

- "The library opened in 1990." → **True**
- "The library opened in 1995." → **False**
- "The library is the largest in the city." → **Not Given** (size compared to other libraries is never mentioned)

The most common mistake is answering False when the answer is Not Given. Ask yourself: does the text **contradict** this, or does it simply **not mention** it?

Watch for qualifying words

Small words change the meaning of a statement completely: **all, some, most, only, always, often, never, usually, may, must**. "Some scientists agree" is not the same as "All scientists agree."

Do's and don'ts

Do	Don't
Attempt Passage 3 first, while your mind is fresh	Don't spend more than about 22 minutes on any one passage
Skim the passage first for the general idea	Don't read the whole passage word by word before looking at the questions
Start each passage with overview questions (matching headings, whole-passage summary)	Don't start with the slowest detail questions
Read the instructions and word limit for every question group	Don't write more words than allowed ("NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS" means 1 or 2)
Copy words from the passage exactly, with correct spelling	Don't change the form of a word (plural, tense) unless the sentence needs it
Write answers directly on the answer sheet as you go (paper test)	Don't plan to transfer answers at the end; there is no extra time
Judge True / False / Not Given only on what the text says	Don't use your own knowledge or opinions
Move on if a question takes too long, and mark it to return to	Don't get stuck on one question while easier marks wait
Guess any unanswered question before time ends	Don't leave blanks; there is no negative marking
For TFNG / YNNG, write the full word or letter as the instructions ask (T / F / NG)	Don't mix the two sets (writing Yes for a True / False question loses the mark)

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Do	Don’t
Use capital letters if your handwriting is unclear (paper test)	Don’t write two answers for one question hoping one is right; it’s marked wrong

Common traps

Trap	What happens	How to avoid it
Word matching	An option repeats exact words from the text but means something different	Prefer the option that matches the **meaning**; exact word matches are often distractors
False vs Not Given	Choosing False when the text simply doesn’t mention the point	Only answer False if the text clearly contradicts the statement
Qualifiers	Missing words like *some, all, only, always, may*	Underline qualifiers in the statement and compare them with the text
Similar headings	Two headings look right for one paragraph	Choose the heading that covers the **whole** paragraph, not one detail in it
Word limit	Writing “the new public library” when the limit is 2 words	Drop words the sentence doesn’t need; articles usually go first
Grammar of the gap	The answer is right but the wrong form (“protect” instead of “protection”)	Read the full sentence and check the word fits grammatically
Time drain	Spending 30 minutes on Passage 3	Set a time limit for each passage and stick to it
Unknown words	Panicking at difficult vocabulary	Use context; most hard words aren’t needed to answer the questions

Useful links to practice

Practise full passages under a 60-minute timer, then review every wrong answer: find the sentence in the passage that proves the right answer.

Resource	What it offers
IELTS Master – Academic Reading tests	Over 300 Academic reading tests online, plus a General Training section and Cambridge tests
KeenIELTS – Reading	Full Academic and General Training reading passages with all question types and instant scoring
British Council – free Academic Reading practice	Official sample tasks for each question type with answer keys, plus a full test in the computer format
IELTS.org – Academic sample questions	Official sample questions from the test owners
IDP IELTS – free practice tests	Practice by skill and question type from the other main test provider
Magoosh – Reading practice resources	A round-up of free full reading tests and practice sets for each question type

All resources above are free. For daily practice, read one article a day from a quality English source such as BBC News, The Guardian or National Geographic, and note new words with their synonyms.

MEHAK HUSSAIN